

the faster USB2.0 interface, which can transfer data at a maximum speed of 480 Mbps. Of course, to take advantage of this, you need a USB2.0-compatible PC. Digital cameras also come with the A/V port, using which one can view images on a television set.

Usability Does Matter

Since most low-end digital cameras come with some level of manual override, getting to any feature using the menu needs to be easy. As you move towards better cameras, the complexities increase. High-end cameras have more features and manual overrides. This in turn means a deeper and more complex menu structure. Navigating through such a menu can be a problem if it is not well laid out. The problem gets compounded if the buttons aren't placed intuitively. Therefore, while checking the other aspects of a camera such as the megapixel count, number of flash modes etc, make sure that the menu is easy to navigate and buttons are easily accessible.

Kodak cameras have menus with the easiest navigation. Every feature is neatly arranged and the sub-menus are just a few clicks away. Also, the menu is standardised for all their cameras, so an upgrade from a low-end camera to a higher-end one is easy.

Sony, on the other hand, has a cumbersome menu with tiny captions, which takes a while getting used to. One needs to remember that a compact camera will have tiny buttons, and menu navigation will therefore get a little tedious.

What Size And Shape Suits You?

With the reduction in size, the form factor of a digital camera has also changed. If you take a look at the current generation of digital cameras, you will notice that they are not plain boxes with a flash and a shutter button. Nowadays, you have ergonomically-designed cameras such as the Sony DSC-P100, and the Exilim from Casio, which is thin and fits snugly in your pocket. Even heavy-duty, performance-oriented cameras such as the Kodak 6490 with 10X optical zoom have extremely compact bodies, and are not very heavy.

The digital camera, however, is not devoid of its share of problems—first and foremost,



An inside view of a standard digital camera

Memory Capacity

Digital Camera Type	16 MB	32 MB	64 MB	128 MB	256 MB	512 MB	1 GB
3-megapixel	13	26	53	106	213	426	853
4-megapixel	8	16	32	64	128	256	512
5-megapixel	6	12	25	51	102	204	409
6-megapixel	5	10	20	40	80	160	320

Table explaining number of images that can be stored by different size media when used with different megapixel cameras

storage capacity and battery life. Most cameras come with very little memory—usually 8 to 16 MB. This makes it difficult for shutterbugs, as a 16 MB card cannot hold more than 20 images taken at a 3-megapixel resolution. So, if you are planning on an extensive outdoor shoot, it is advisable to spend some extra money and get a 512 MB memory card.

Battery life is another major area of concern: if the camera has a regular Li-Ion battery, you need to purchase at least one extra battery pack. But this is not going to help you much if you are on vacation and do not have a power source to recharge your batteries. If your camera runs on regular batteries, you can carry as many extra batteries as possible. This, however, will prove expensive in the long run.

The Current Market

The grey market is still the market of choice for most digital camera buyers in India. The obvious reason for this is price.

The Nikon Coolpix 5100 is the best example of the price difference. The camera, if purchased from an authorised dealer, would set you back by Rs 20,800—but is available for just Rs 11,750 in the grey market. On one leading online site, the same model is priced even lower—at Rs 10,500. The HP Photosmart, which we tested in October 2004, had an official price tag of Rs 29,990, and the grey market price is Rs 14,000.

Companies such as Kodak, however, sell their cameras at competitive prices, making it difficult to find their models in the grey market.

With big brands such as Sony, Canon and HP having already set up shop in the country, and with duties on electronic goods decreasing after every Budget, it makes sense to buy a genuine product from an authorised distributor. This gets you a warranty, which takes care of any damage to your camera within the warranty period, and even a replacement if there is any serious flaw in your camera.

Companies have also come up with innovative ways to wean the consumer off the grey market. For instance, Sony sends a representative to your house to walk you through the various features of the camera. This service is, however, limited to only a few cities. Then there's also Kodak, which has a toll free number to help you arrange for a professional photographer.

The price factor is still very important in India, than in some other countries—so how the 'white' market fares vis-a-vis the grey market remains to be seen. ☒

aliasgar_pardawala@thinkdigit.com

Vendors' Contact Numbers

- ☐ Sony India Ltd: 1600 1111 88
- ☐ Kodak: 1600 2249 49
- ☐ Canon: 39010101
- ☐ HP: 1600 447 737